

Technology News

The future of mobile phone

The mobile phone of the future will finish the laptop market, says executive vice president of Nokia's world-wide markets, Anssi Vanjoki. It will be more of a computer. It will enable map and GPS applications. So you can see all your friends on a map, see where they are moving to, and send an SMS or make a call with just a click on their picture.

The virtual world will become an integral part of the real world. And, people will interact more virtually through mobile phones, than in real life. Social networking will achieve a new paradigm with mobile phone and the society being much more connected.

Many interesting features can be developed. For instance, moms can see where their kids are, all the time. Phones will be fully integrated with refrigerators, TVs, cars and all other computing or electronic devices. Currency notes will become rare. Your phone will store money, order milk and replenish vegetables by ordering them digitally. The mobile phone will become the brain behind all your social and virtual dealings and the master computer which controls all electronic devices.

High-tech gifts

Here are some high-tech products to watch out for in 2009.

The Nabaztag is a rabbit-shaped electronic device that recognises voice commands in five languages. It is Wi-Fi-enabled and can read you weather forecasts, RSS feeds, SMS and much more, straight from the Internet, in 36 different languages. If you prefer non-verbal communication, it can also flash its lights or wiggle its ears to grab your attention,



Nabaztag a rabbit-shaped electronic device that recognises voice commands in five languages

or just play music from an online podcast or radio. The Nabaztag is priced at \$200.

Next in line is Takara Tomy's 5-megapixel Xiao. It is the first digital camera to integrate the inkless Zink printer, which produces dry, full-colour, smudge-proof, tear-proof and water-resistant prints in less than a minute. The Xiao is priced at \$365.

Eye-Fi's 4GB Anniversary Edition of its much-hyped SD memory card turns your digital camera into another smart object that can connect to the World Wide Web. It has double the capacity of previous models. Eye-Fi cards allow your camera to automatically send pictures directly to the Internet or your computer via Wi-Fi. The Eye-Fi 4GB Anniversary Edition SD card is priced at \$130.

No batteries required for future gadgets

High-tech devices will be able to power themselves in the future by converting

pressure waves into energy. So no re-charge will be needed.

The findings, detailed in the journal *Physical Review B*, could have potentially profound effects for low-powered electronic devices such as laptops, personal communicators and a host of other computer-related devices used by everyone from the average consumer to law enforcement officers and even soldiers in the battlefield.

The technology behind this innovation is 'piezoelectrics,' which aims to develop self-powering electronics, eliminating the need for replaceable power supplies, such as batteries. Piezoelectrics are actually materials, such as crystals or ceramics, which generate a significant amount of voltage when a form of mechanical stress (such as a push) is applied.

There are also mechanisms other than 'pushing' that can generate pressure waves to spark energy in piezoelectric materials. Imagine a self-powering cell phone, for instance, that never needs to be charged because it converts sound waves produced by the user into the energy that it needs to keep running.

Electronic tagging of products

The greatest automation opportunity for retailers lies in not having to change shelf-edge labels. Recent UK changes to the VAT regime meant that Sainsbury's had to change 25,000 product pricings. Digitisation would have meant the supermarket did not have to re-print all 25,000 labels.

Computer giant IBM has developed digital shelf labels using electronic paper that can be programmed to self-change or be altered by remote control. Electronic tags using e-ink mean retailers can easily change prices.